

The End of Counting

What Jesus said about forgiving, and where the strength to do it comes from



> **Matthew 18:21–22** *"Then Peter came up and said to him, 'Lord, how often will my brother sin against me, and I forgive him? As many as seven times?' Jesus said to him, 'I do not say to you seven times, but seventy-seven times.'"*

Nobody decides to become a scorekeeper. It happens to us. Somebody wounds you, and without a single conscious choice a page opens in your heart with their name at the top. Every slight after that gets an entry, and you can recite the entries years later: the words, the room, the look on their face.

Peter was keeping one. He was not being stingy. The rabbis taught three. Peter doubled it and added one, and seven was a holy number besides. He thought he was aiming at heaven. Jesus answered with a number too big to track, then a story about two ledgers, and then he went to a cross and closed the books for good.

This short study walks through what Jesus said that day, and why the people who have been forgiven are the only people who can really forgive.

Five things to remember

1. **Forgiving means releasing a debt.** It is something your hand does, even before your feelings agree.
2. **Jesus ended the counting.** Mercy has no limit to keep track of.
3. **You have been forgiven far more** than anyone will ever owe you.
4. **You forgive just as the Lord forgave you,** out of what you received, again and again.
5. **Releasing is different from trusting again.** The first you always owe. The second takes two.

1. The number that ends numbers

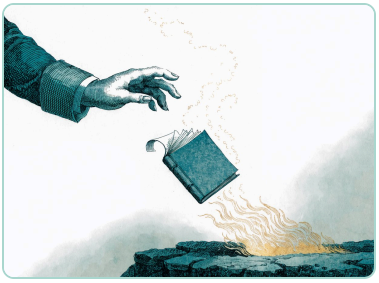
Some Bibles read “seventy-seven times,” others “seventy times seven.” Chasing the exact figure misses the point. Either way the number is chosen to be uncountable in practice. Try it. Resolve to forgive a man exactly 490 times and not once more. You will need a notebook. Every wound becomes an entry, and by offense three hundred you are a full-time bookkeeper of your own pain. Jesus picks a number so big that the only sane response is to throw the notebook in the fire.

And he is quoting. In Genesis 4:24 a swaggering man named Lamech, Cain’s descendant, boasts that he will avenge himself “seventy-sevenfold.” That number sat in the Bible for thousands of years like a scar. Then Jesus picks it up and turns Lamech’s number of cursing into a number of blessing. Lamech multiplied vengeance. Jesus multiplies mercy.

> **ἀφίημι** *aphiēmi*
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> The word for “forgive” in Peter’s question. It means **to send away, to release, to let go**. The same verb is used for a fever leaving a body and for a ship casting off its lines. Jesus uses it when the disciples “leave” their nets (Matt. 4:20), and when he cries from the cross, “Father, forgive them” (Luke 23:34). It is the language of a creditor opening his hand. (Word roots are a guide, not a proof, but here the root and the way the New Testament uses the word agree.)

If forgiving is releasing, two things follow.

- **The debt is real.** You cannot let go of a debt that does not exist. Forgiveness never says the wound was small.
- **You can do it before you feel it.** Nobody is told to manufacture warm feelings. You are told to let go of the debt. The hand opens by faith, and the heart follows by grace.
- **Burn the notebook, not the memory.** You will not forget, and God does not ask you to. He asks you to stop adding entries, stop rehearsing them, and stop bringing them to the next argument as evidence.
- **Watch for Lamech.** The old instinct to answer a wound with a bigger one is still in you. When you catch yourself building the case for revenge, remember whose number that is.



The hand that kept the book opens, and the book goes into the fire.

2. Two ledgers

Jesus does not leave Peter with a number. He tells him a story with two ledgers in it. A king settles accounts, and a servant is brought in who owes ten thousand talents. A talent was roughly twenty years of a laborer's wages. Ten thousand of them is two hundred thousand years of work, a debt no man could pay in a thousand lifetimes. On his knees the servant says, "Have patience with me, and I will pay you everything." He still thinks it is a payment problem. Anyone who has ever tried to earn his way back to God knows that sentence from the inside.

> **Matthew 18:27** *"And out of pity for him, the master of that servant released him and forgave him the debt."*

The words "out of pity" translate a Greek word for being moved deep in your gut. The Gospels use it almost only of Jesus and of the God-figures in his parables, like the father who runs to the prodigal son (Luke 15:20). It is God's heart turning over at the sight of a man who cannot pay. The servant asked for a payment plan. God does not extend your terms. He tears up the note.

Now the second ledger. The same servant walks out and finds a fellow servant who owes him a hundred denarii, about three months' wages. He "seized him and began to choke him" (v. 28). The man who was just released grabs a throat. He hears the very plea he made to the king, refuses it, and puts the man in prison.

Feel the ratio. Ten thousand talents against a hundred denarii is roughly six hundred thousand to one. The hundred denarii was a real debt. But next to what you have been forgiven, the worst thing anyone has ever done to you is a hundred denarii. Your wound was real. Your pardon was enormous.

The sentence to write on your wall

The unforgiving servant was not a man who had never been forgiven. He was a man who had forgotten it. The wonder faded before he reached the street. Unforgiveness is first a failure of memory. Bitterness grows in one kind of soil: a heart that has lost sight of how much it has been forgiven.



Two ledgers. He forgot the first before he reached the second.

> **Matthew 18:32–33** *"You wicked servant! I forgave you all that debt because you pleaded with me. And should not you have had mercy on your fellow servant, as I had mercy on you?"*

Then Jesus adds a hard word: "So also my heavenly Father will do to every one of you, if you do not forgive your brother from your heart" (v. 35). Do not soften this, and do not misread it. Your forgiving does not *earn* God's forgiving. The king forgave first, freely. Your forgiving *shows* that his forgiveness has really reached you, the way fruit shows a living root. A heart forgiven a fortune cannot, while the wonder is still warm in it, throttle a brother over a few coins. When you find a grudge you will not release, do not ask, "Will God still forgive me?" Ask, "Have I forgotten what He already did?" Then go back to the throne room and look.

And notice where the unforgiving man ends up: in prison. The unforgiving heart is already in a cell, the lock is on the inside, and the prisoner holds the key. He tells himself his refusal is costing the other man. It is costing him.

3. As the Lord forgave you

> **Colossians 3:13** *"Bearing with one another and, if one has a complaint against another, forgiving each other; as the Lord has forgiven you, so you also must forgive."*

Here Paul reaches for a different word, *charizomai*, built on *charis*, which means grace: God's kindness that nobody earns. It means to forgive the way you give a gift. Then one small word ties it to its source: "just as." Forgive *just as* the Lord forgave you, in the same measure and from the same supply. You do not make this yourself. You receive it and you give it away.

That is why trying harder fails. Anyone who has tried to forgive by sheer effort knows the root grows back faster than you can pull it. The cure is to go back to the cross and stand there until the mountain of your own forgiven sin looms so large that the debt you are clutching looks like the few coins it always was.

4. Seven times in a day

> **Luke 17:4** *"If he sins against you seven times in the day, and turns to you seven times, saying, 'I repent,' you must forgive him."*

Forgiveness is less like a wedding and more like a marriage: ten thousand small acts of keeping the vow, long after the music stops. Many people decide they failed because the resentment came back a week later. Jesus never promised it would vanish. **The resurgence of resentment is not proof that you never forgave. It is the next occasion for forgiving.** No wonder the apostles answered, "Increase our faith!" These men had watched him still storms and raise the dead, and they still knew this was beyond them. They did not ask for more willpower or a better technique. They asked for faith. That is the posture of every real forgiver: the weak man holding out an empty cup. The asking is already the beginning of the answer.

5. Releasing is different from trusting again

OFTEN HEARD AS

If I forgive him, I have to trust him again as if nothing happened.

WHAT JESUS TEACHES

Luke 17 says, "if he repents, forgive him." Yet from the cross Jesus forgave men who had not repented. The open hand you always owe. Restored trust takes two.

To the woman whose abuser will never admit what he did, the call is not "trust him as before." The call is to release the bitterness, hand him to the God who hears the cry of the wronged, and refuse to let hatred have your heart. You are not obligated to manufacture a reconciliation the other party has made impossible. But you are invited, for your own sake, to walk out of the cell.

THE NUMBER

Ends the limit

Stop counting the chances you give.

THE STORY

Ends the forgetting

Remember the debt the King tore up.

THE SOURCE

Ends the trying

Pass on what you were given.

Five ways to live this out this week

1. **Find your page.** Write the name at the top and, honestly, the entries under it. The ledger does its worst work in the dark.
2. **Release before you feel like it.** Say it out loud to God: "I send this away. I will not collect."
3. **Do the ratio.** Put your worst wound next to your own forgiven debt.
4. **Expect it to come back.** When resentment comes back at lunch, you have not failed. You have arrived at the next occasion.
5. **Forgive in company.** Tell one brother or sister the name on your page and what you are releasing.

For discussion

1. Where do you keep a quiet limit on how many chances someone gets?
2. How does hearing forgiveness as an open hand, not a feeling, change what you can do this week?
3. What has the score you are keeping cost you? Who is the real prisoner?
4. When you tried to forgive by willpower, what were you drawing on?

The ledger with your name on it can be closed. "He forgave us all our trespasses, by cancelling the record of debt that stood against us with its legal demands. This he set aside, nailing it to the cross" (Col. 2:13–14). The Judge stepped down from the bench and paid the fine himself, in the person of his Son. If you are still offering God a payment plan, stop. Turn from your sin and trust Christ, who paid it all. Hear him say, "I, I am he who blots out your transgressions for my own sake, and I will not remember your sins" (Isa. 43:25). The heart that believes that is the only heart free enough, and full enough, to forgive.

Ready to go deeper? Read the full study, free.

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